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For example, some roles might not seek her out once they learned she was married.

That would indeed be a loss.

But Liang Shi had never thought of hiding this matter; she simply didn't want Xu Qingzhu to be exposed to the public eye.

There was nothing to hide about her marital status.

Compared to her family, her career wasn't as important.

Liang Shi's candid response actually made everyone less interested, and the buzz quickly died down.

She had now aired two productions and was currently filming another. The roles complemented her well. Since she hadn't planned to become a top-tier celebrity, she wasn't going down that route anyway.

News of a not-so-famous actress being married wasn't considered juicy gossip¹ to netizens.

This matter happened to distract Liang Shi, and by the time she finished handling it, she realized over two hours had already passed.

Liang Shi went to pick up the results together with Xu Qingzhu.

Just like how Liang Shi had accompanied Xu Qingzhu throughout the entire process when Xu Qingzhu acknowledged Su Yao, this time Xu Qingzhu also stood firmly by her side.

To be honest, Liang Shi had imagined many possible outcomes and had even rationally thought of ways to respond to them.

The result was within expectations, yet she still found it unbelievable.

The expert opinion in the identification report stated: The probability of a biological parent-child relationship being established is 99.9999%.

In other words, she was indeed Zhu Mingqi's daughter.

After receiving the identification report, Liang Shi sat on a bench with Xu Qingzhu in a daze.

She didn't know what she was thinking about; her thoughts were simply scattered.

It took her a long while to adjust her emotions before she stood up and said to Xu Qingzhu, "Let's go."

Xu Qingzhu didn't ask what she planned to do, just quietly accompanied her.

However, after learning the results, Liang Shi still sent the news to Zhao Xuning.

Zhao Xuning only replied coldly: 【Got it.】

She had probably guessed it long ago.

Liang Shi didn't mention acknowledging her relatives; she felt it would be too abrupt.

Perhaps it was because the Shen family's relationships were currently very harmonious, and the Shen family's status was too high—she felt a sense of inferiority.

Also a sense of powerlessness.

Just like before, she was still afraid to face the unknown.

Because she didn't want to break the current balance, she chose to temporarily avoid it.

That evening, Liang Shi also fell into silence and didn't seem to be in a good mood.

Xu Qingzhu said that since she was going to struggle with it either way, she might as well just say it and let others struggle with it instead.

But Liang Shi shook her head vigorously.

Later, the two lay in bed. After the lights were turned off, Liang Shi said in a low voice, "In the past, I imagined many times what my parents would be like, what their personalities would be, whether I would have siblings. After coming here, I thought those were my parents and family, but later found out they weren't. Now I've discovered that my actual parents and family are so dazzling, but I'm so ordinary."

"Shen Fenghe has an MBA from a prestigious foreign university and also studied psychology. Shen Hui is a graduate student at a famous foreign medical school. Shen Siyan goes to Qingyi University." Liang Shi said, "I never went to university. I feel this is a regret, but it's also a regret that can't be remedied."

"I don't fit in with them, just like when I tried to integrate into your world—it took so much effort. But because it was you, I was willing to work hard, to change, to accept all the worlds around you that I might never have been exposed to, to try to understand."

"But now, I'm facing an even bigger change, and I don't want to change anymore. They're all wonderful, but I feel like I'm not from the same world as them. I don't want to compete with them for anything, nor do I want to put myself in an unfamiliar environment. It's like being naked with everyone looking at you, about to set off a new wave of commotion. I'm afraid I'll be exhausted, so I retreat."

"Xu Qingzhu." Liang Shi murmured softly, calling Xu Qingzhu's name with tender affection, carrying a hint of bitterness, "Am I very cowardly?"

"Mm." Xu Qingzhu responded, then kissed her lips in the darkness. "Our Teacher Liang has been so wronged."

Like coaxing a child.

But Liang Shi chuckled softly, "I'm not wronged. At least I know they're still alive, and I wasn't the one who was abandoned."

If she had found out she was abandoned, she would probably be very sad.

She would feel like she had been abandoned by the whole world.

But now knowing that she wasn't abandoned, and that there were people at home who missed her—this was also a kind of comfort.

"So you're never going to acknowledge them?" Xu Qingzhu asked her. "Keep this secret hidden away?"

Liang Shi shook her head. "I haven't decided yet. Who knows, maybe one day on impulse I'll blurt out the secret."

Xu Qingzhu nodded. "That works too."

She completely respected Liang Shi's decision.

"Just like you said, we went to verify this just to hold the initiative in our own hands." Liang Shi said, "So now we're in the dominant position."

Xu Qingzhu responded softly, "Yes."

Footnotes:

¹ "Juicy gossip" - The original Chinese uses "瓜" (guā), literally meaning "melon." In Chinese internet slang, "eating melons" (吃瓜) refers to watching drama unfold or consuming gossip as a spectator, similar to eating popcorn while watching a show. So "不算瓜" means "not considered gossip worth paying attention to."